



Unani





Outline



- **Introduction**
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- **Global Practice**
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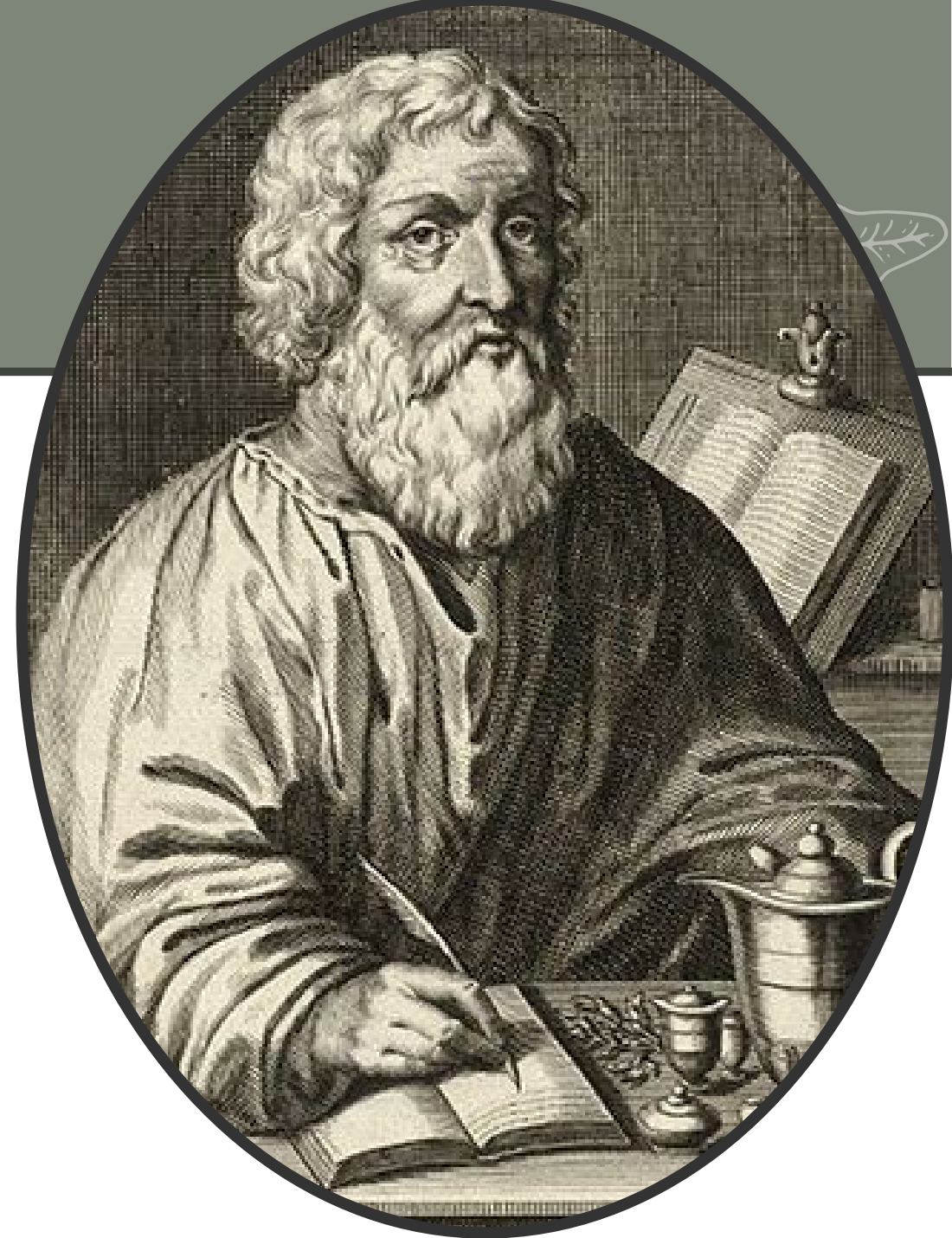
Introduction

- Unani medicine is a traditional Greco-Arabic system of healing, rooted in Hippocratic teachings.
- Preventive, promotive, curative and rehabilitative healthcare with holistic approach.
- Highlights diet and digestion as key and treatments to health



History

- Unani began in Greece, with roots in Egyptian and Mesopotamian medicine.
- ***Hippocrates(460-377BC)*** established Unani as a science providing its theoretical framework.
- ***Dioscorides*** documented medicinal herbs, and ***Galen (131–210 AD)*** systematized medical knowledge
- ***Rhazes (850–925 AD)*** and ***Avicenna (980–1037 AD)*** expanded Unani through research in surgery, pharmacology, and theory.



Core Theoretical Principles



- Unani medicine views health as a dynamic balance within the body and with the environment.
- This balance is maintained through harmony of elements (**Arkān**), humours (**Akhlāṭ**), and temperament (**Mizāj**).
- Disease occurs when this natural balance is disturbed by internal or external factors.
- Treatment focuses on restoring balance through personalized therapy, diet, lifestyle changes, and appropriate drugs.

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Theoretical principles lie on the concept of :

- The 7 Natural Factors (Umür Öabé‘iyya)
- The Doctrine of Four Humors (Al-Akhlāt)
- The Concept of Temperament (Al-Mizāj)
- The Principles of Diagnosis (Uñül-i Tashkhéñ)
- The Vis Medicatrix Naturae (Quwwat-e-Mudabbira / Tabiyat)
- Six Essential Factors

1. The 7 Natural Factors (Umür Öabé'iyya)



These are the physiological pillars necessary for maintaining life and health

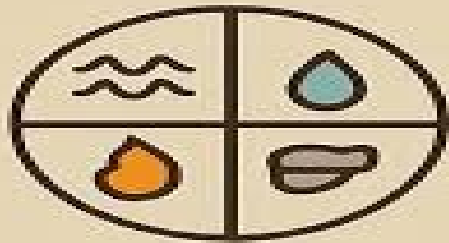
- ❖ ***Elements (Arkän)***: Basic components that make up humans, the universe, and drugs.
- ❖ ***Humours (Akhläö)***: Forms taken by elements in living beings; health depends on the balance of blood, phlegm, yellow bile, and black bile.
- ❖ ***Temperament (Mizäj)***: Overall quality of the body or substance (hot, cold, moist, dry) determined by dominant elements and humours
- ❖ ***Organs (A'òä')***: The physical body.

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- ❖ *Pneuma (Arwäü)*: The subtle substance
 - ✓ (i) having vitality and
 - ✓ (ii) acting as carrier of physiological powers.
- ❖ *Faculties (Quwä)*: The physiological powers responsible for corresponding basic functions of the organism i.e. life, nutrition, sensation, movement and reproduction.
- ❖ *Functions (Af'äl)*: Functions of various organs.

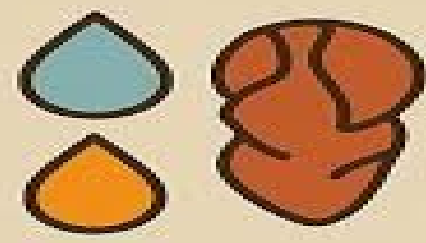
UMOOR-E-TABBIYA



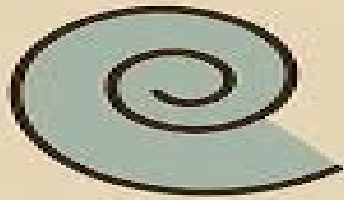
ARKAN
(ELEMENTS)



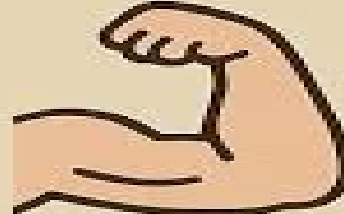
MIZAJ
(TEMPERAMENT)



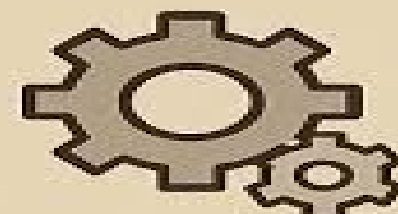
AZA
(ORGANS)



ARWAH
(PNEUMA/VITAL
FORCES)



QUWA
(FACULTIES/POWERS)



AF'AL
(FUNCTIONS)



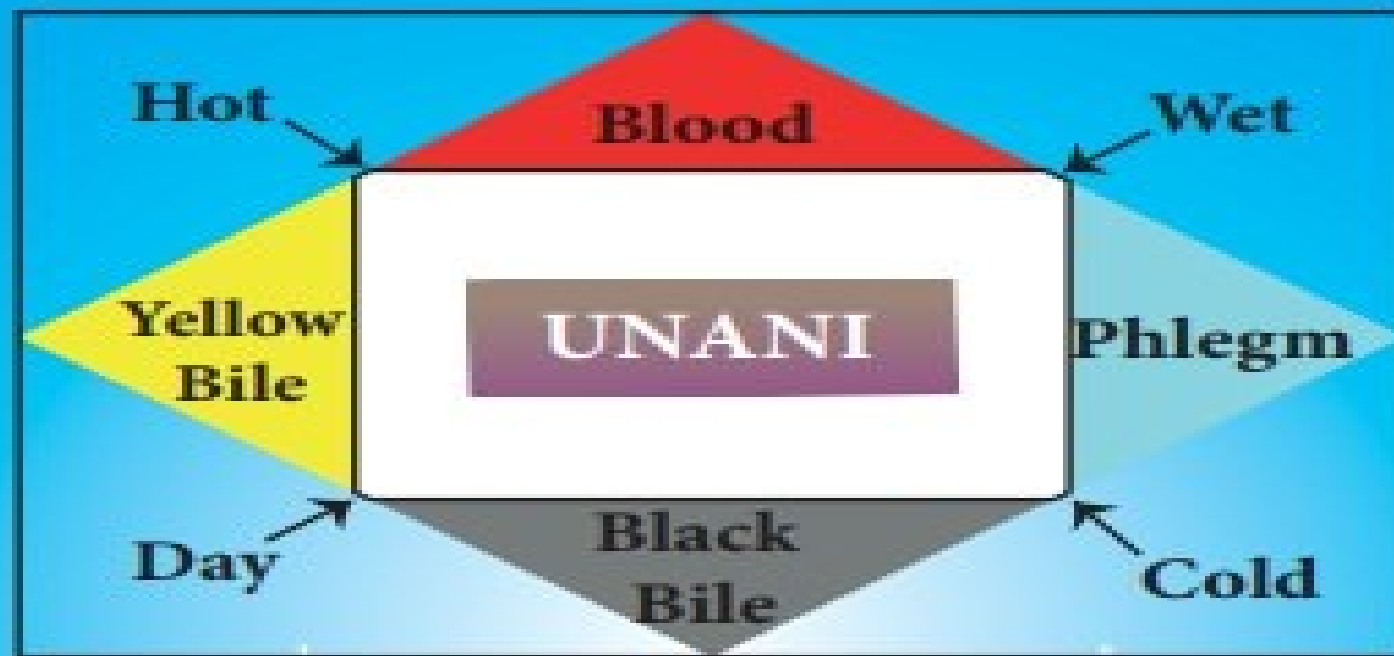
**ASBAB-E-SITTA
ZAROORIYA**
(SIX ESSENTIAL CAUSES)

#AyushInanIndia

2. The Doctrine of Four Humors (Al-Akhlā)



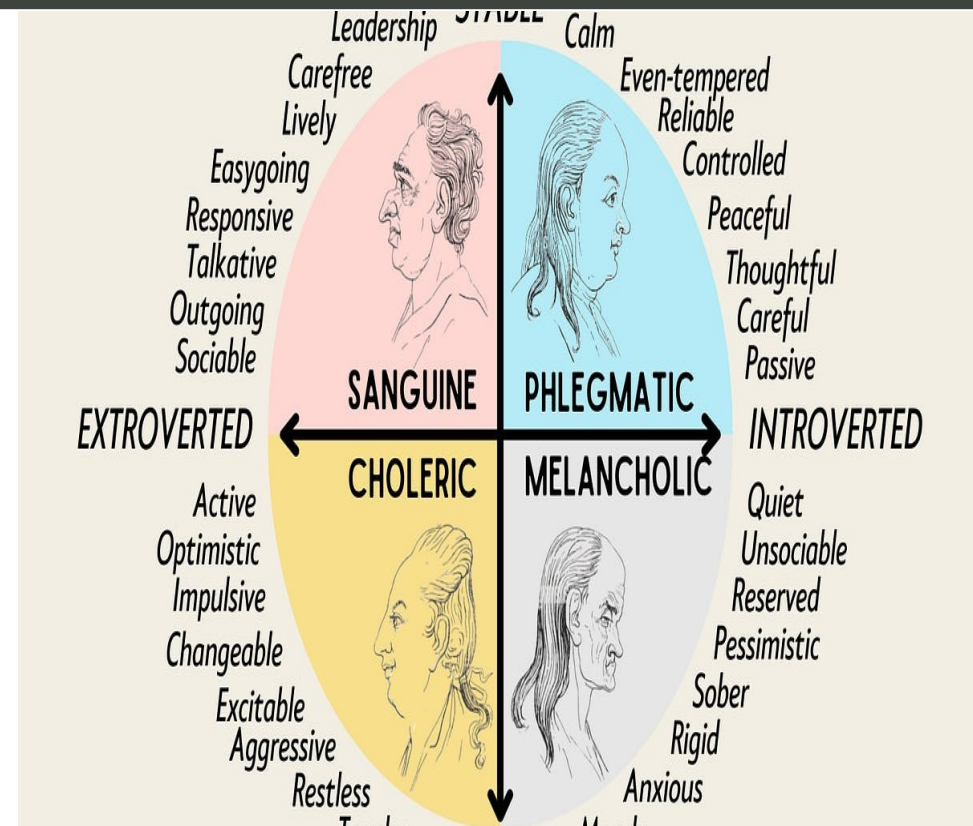
- ✓ Derived from Hippocratic theory, it is the basis of Unani physiology and pathology.
 - 1. Blood (Dam):** Hot and Moist. Nourishes the body and provides vitality.
 - 2. Phlegm (Balgham):** Cold and Moist. Provides moisture and structural integrity.
 - 3. Yellow Bile (Şafrā):** Hot and Dry. Governs metabolism and digestion.
 - 4. Black Bile (Sawdā):** Cold and Dry. Supports structure and bone formation.
- ✓ Imbalance (*Su'-e-Mizaj*) in the quality or quantity of these humors is the root cause of disease.



Four Basic Elements of human body	Qualities or states of human body	Four “humors” of human body
Earth	Cold	Blood
Air	Dry	Phlegm(Sputum)
Water	Wet	Yellow Bile
Fire	Hot	Black Bile

3. The Concept of Temperament (Al-Mizāj)

- Every individual possesses a unique temperament
- Its a composite of the four primary qualities (**Hot, Cold, Wet, Dry**).
- An individual's *Mizaj* determines their physical, psychological, and physiological predispositions.
- Diagnosis and treatment aim to restore the patient's individual constitutional balance.



Types of *Mizaj* (Temperament)

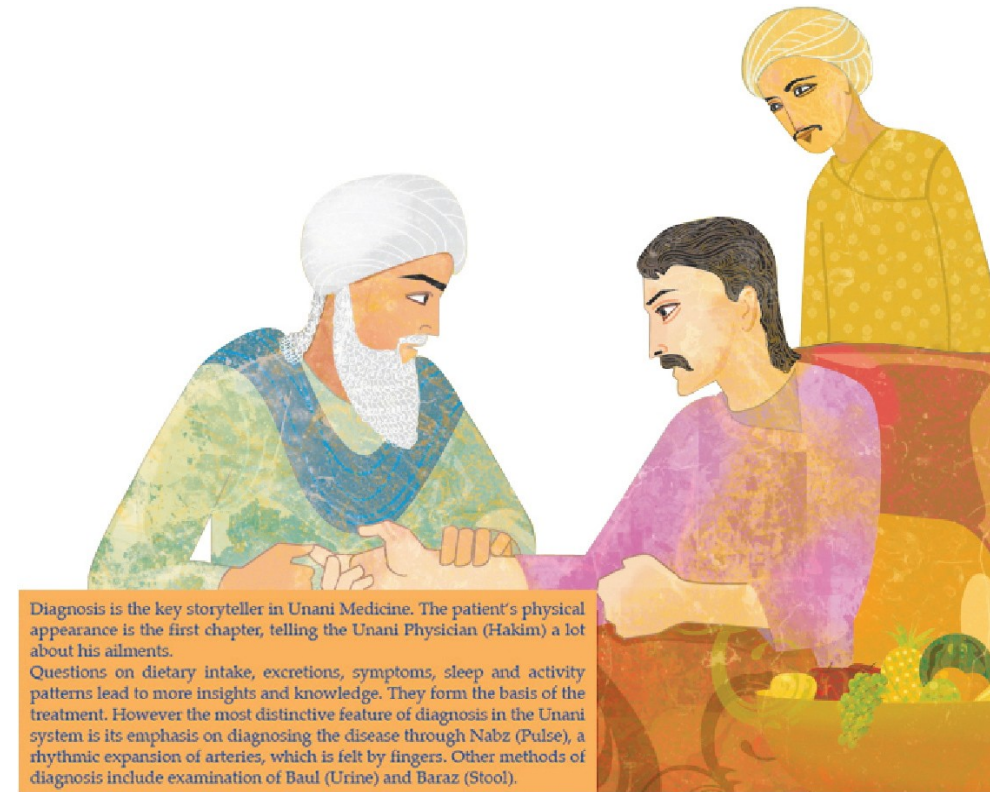
4. The Vis Medicatrix Naturae (Quwwat-e-Mudabbira / Tabiyat)



- Concept of Natural healing Power
- Unani emphasizes the body's inherent ability to regulate and heal itself, viewing this self-healing power as central to health.
- The physician's role is to support the body's natural healing by removing obstacles, not just treating symptoms.
- Treatments support the body's natural processes, restore balance, and enhance overall well-being.

5. The Principles of Diagnosis (Uñül-i Tashkhén)

- **Pulse Diagnosis (Nabz):** Assessment of the radial pulse to evaluate the state of various organs and humors based on rate, strength, and rhythm.
- **Urine Analysis (Baul):** Color, consistency, transparency, and sediment.
- **Stool Examination (Barāz).**
- **Physical Inspection:** Examination of the tongue, eyes, skin, and general body habitus.



Diagnosis is the key storyteller in Unani Medicine. The patient's physical appearance is the first chapter, telling the Unani Physician (Hakim) a lot about his ailments. Questions on dietary intake, excretions, symptoms, sleep and activity patterns lead to more insights and knowledge. They form the basis of the treatment. However the most distinctive feature of diagnosis in the Unani system is its emphasis on diagnosing the disease through Nabz (Pulse), a rhythmic expansion of arteries, which is felt by fingers. Other methods of diagnosis include examination of Baul (Urine) and Baraz (Stool).

6.Six Essential Factors

- In Unani medicine, the Six Essential Factors (Asbāb Sitta Āhārīyya) maintain health by aligning lifestyle with a person's temperament.
- These are
 - Atmospheric Air
 - Food & Drink
 - Physical Activity & Rest
 - Psychological Activity & Rest
 - Sleep & Wakefulness and
 - Elimination & Retention



Treatment approach



Unani System of Medicine describes following modes of treatment:

- Regimenal Therapy ('Iläj bi'l-Tadbér)
- Dietotherapy ('Iläj bi'l-Ghidhä')
- Pharmacotherapy ('Iläj bi'l-Dawä')
- Surgery ('Iläj bi'l-Yad)
- However, the first preference of treatment is given to regimenal therapy and diet, and drugs and surgery are used only if required.

A. Regimenal therapy



- Regimenal therapy comprises mostly non-medicinal procedures
- Lifestyles for preservation of health and treatment of disease are modulated.
- Ancient Unani physicians, have described various regimens for the management of diseases, either independently or in combination with other therapies.

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- Regimenal therapy Includes: *Changes in diet, Physical exercise, Lifestyle modification.*
- Measures to eliminate the morbid *Humours (Tanqiya)* from the body or divert them by:

*Cupping (Ûijämat),
Leeching (Ta'léq),
Purgation (Ishäl),
Diuresis (Idrär-i Bawl),
Diaphoresis (Ta'réq),
Counter Irritation (Éläm),*

*Massage (Dalk)
Venesection/Bloodletting (Fañd)
Emesis (Qay')
Enema (Ûuqna)
Expectoration (Tanféth)
Sitz Bath (Äbzan) etc.*



Galen performing cupping (Üijämat)



Dry Cupping



Wet Cupping



Massage (Dalk)



Sitz Bath

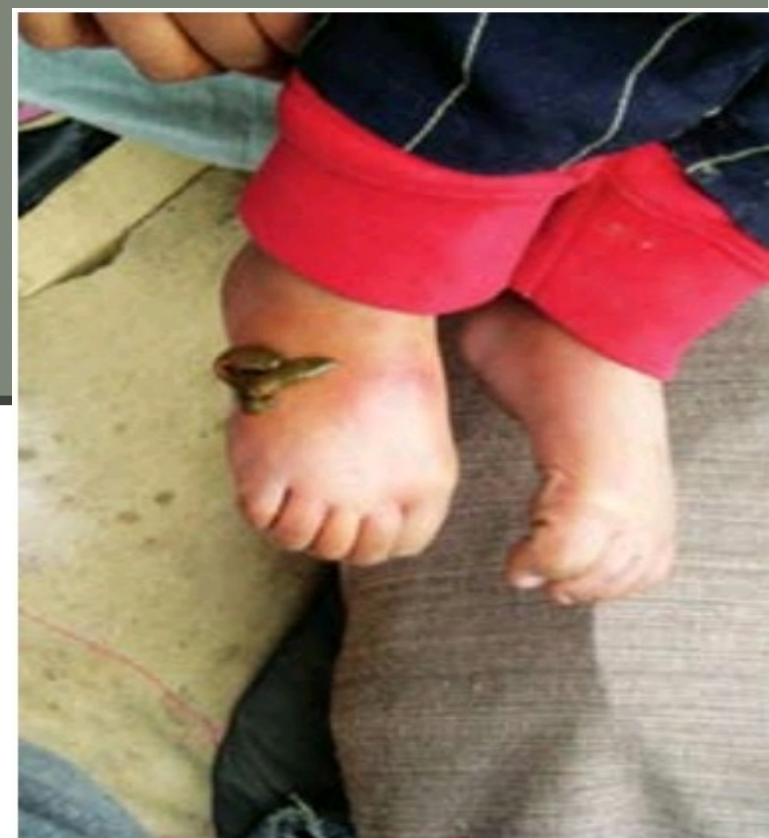


Figure 20: Leeching (Ta'liq) on a frostbite patient

Leeching (Ta'léq)

B. Dietotherapy



- Unani System of Medicine lays great stress on treating certain ailments by:
 - ✓ administration of specific diets
 - ✓ regulating the quality and quantity of food.
- Various foods have pharmacological actions too(laxative, diuretic and diaphoretic).
- The weakness of certain organs is corrected by administering the same organ of an animal by way of food.

C. Pharmacotherapy (Ilāj-bi'l-Dawā):



- Natural drugs, primarily from botanical sources (~90%), and supplemented by minerals and animal products.
 - **Fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*)** for digestion.
 - **Licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*)** as a demulcent.
 - **Senna (*Cassia angustifolia*)** as a purgative.
 - **Black Seed (*Nigella sativa*)** for a wide range of ailments.
 - **Myrobalan (*Terminalia chebula*)** as a rejuvenative.

Cont'd



- **Dosage Forms:** Medicines are compounded into elegant preparations
 - ✓ **Majoon** (electuary paste)
 - ✓ **Safoof** (fine powder)
 - ✓ **Joshanda** (herbal decoction)
 - ✓ **Arq** (hydro-distillate)
 - ✓ **Qurs** (tablets)
 - ✓ **Marham** (ointment).



Fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*)



Black Seed (*Nigella sativa*)



Licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*)



Senna (*Cassia angustifolia*)



Myrobalan (*Terminalia chebula*)

D. Surgery (Ilāj-bi'l-Yad)

- Considered a last resort
- Employed only when pharmacotherapy fails.
- **Abü al-Qāsim al-Zahrāwé**
- The book “*Kitāb al-Tañréf li-man ‘ajiza ‘ani’l-Ta‘léf*” describe instruments and procedures for fractures, cataracts, and abscesses.



Abü al-Qāsim al-Zahrāwé



Figure 21: A page from book Kitāb al-Tañrif li-man ‘ajiza ‘ani’l-Ta‘lif showing some surgical instruments.

Surgical Instruments

Areas of Practice (Clinical Specialization)



- **Chronic & lifestyle disorders:** Diabetes, obesity, hypertension, and dyslipidemia.
- **Musculoskeletal & gastrointestinal issues:** Arthritis, gout, ulcers, hepatitis, constipation.
- **Skin & respiratory conditions:** Eczema, psoriasis, vitiligo, acne, asthma, bronchitis, rhinitis.
- **Reproductive & preventive care:** Infertility, menstrual disorders, and geriatric health through diet and lifestyle.

Global Practice



- Unani medicine is widely practiced in **India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Iran, and Sri Lanka.**
- Recognized in national healthcare systems and taught in universities in several countries.(Majorly India)
- Unani companies like Hamdard drive local and international markets,
- Bangladesh's Unani trade around **US \$20 million** and Hamdard India's annual turnover about **US \$95 million**

Conclusion



- Unani medicine is a holistic and time-tested system that promotes health by restoring balance within the body, using natural therapies, lifestyle management, and herbal medicines, and continues to play a significant role in traditional and complementary healthcare worldwide.

Reference



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- *Additional sources: Peer-reviewed articles on Unani pharmacology and clinical trials (2010-2023)*

Thank you



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